

ENTREPRENEURS

AT THE PRIVATE HEALTHCARE INDUSTRY, THEY DID MORE THAN CREATE HOSPITALS. THEY BUILT BUSINESSES OF THEIR OWN. BY **NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA**

clinical practice and build the institutions capable of absorbing it. They did more than create hospitals. They also showed that doctors could become entrepreneurs, inspiring a new generation to build healthcare businesses of their own.

THE FIRST CORPORATE HOSPITAL

Dr Prathap C. Reddy, Founder Chairman of Apollo Hospitals, was a practising cardiologist in the United States before he moved back to India in the early 1970s. What he found on his return bothered him: there was almost nowhere in the country to send a patient who needed com-

plex heart surgery. He kept referring cases abroad, often to the pioneering heart surgeon Dr Denton Cooley.

In 1979, a patient he had referred could not raise the money to travel in time and died at the age of 38. That is the moment Dr Reddy points to when he talks about why he decided to build a hospital in India instead of only practising in one.

"I was shocked to witness the stark lack of medical infrastructure," he says of his early years back in the country. There was no corporate hospital model in India then, and hospitals could not even get bank loans because they were not recognised as an industry. Medical equip-

| 31

PHOTO BY SELVAPRAKASH LAKSHMANAN



DR. DEVI PRASAD SHETTY
FOUNDER, NARAYANA HEALTH
(FY26 REVENUE: ₹7,896 CR)

Cardiac surgeon Dr. Devi Shetty founded Narayana Health in 2001 on the belief that advanced medical treatment could be delivered at lower cost through scale, standardised clinical protocols and operational efficiency. Starting with a single cardiac hospital in Bengaluru, he grew the organisation into a multi-specialty hospital network serving patients across India. His approach has centred around cutting treatment costs without compromising clinical outcomes, while leaning on technology, telemedicine and digital platforms to widen access, particularly for underserved populations.